With the Central government simply not having enough money, references to black money became much more frequent under the Modi regime. The focus on expanding the tax net in a country where only 4.18 per cent[119] of the population pays tax is understandable, but it also led in practice to a culture of what even a government supporter like former Infosys CFO and Board member Mohandas Pai called 'tax-terrorism'.[120] Not since the early 1990s has any government focused on a discourse on black money the way the Modi government has.

Is Modi a Socialist? Summing Up His Government's Economics Approach

What does all this amount to? The journalist Brajesh Kumar Singh, who has closely tracked Modi's career since his first days as chief minister in Ahmedabad, says the Modi government is the 'most left-wing government since independence'.[121] He argues that the Modi model has focused on four broad elements: building a social welfare net (with schemes like Jan Dhan, Ujjwala, and now Jan Arogya), betting on infrastructure spending, creating tent-pole social-sector projects (like toilets with Swachh Bharat in his first term and water with Jal Nidhi in his second), keeping inflation down and focusing on increasing the taxation base.

When Modi came to power, he derided the MNREGA programme as the biggest failure of the Congress. 'That people after sixty years of independence are digging holes to get paid is the best testament to your failure,' he declared in Parliament, pointing to Congress leaders.[122] Yet, after Rahul Gandhi's 'suit-boot ki sarkar' jibe,[123] his government doubled down on MNREGA, increasing its funding to higher levels than were seen under UPA-2. Modi did undertake reforms like GST and the insolvency code, but undertook less privatisation, in his first term, than Vajpayee and focused on big marquee projects like the bullet-train corridor with Japanese funding. In other words, Modi has largely been a statist. He has presided over an increase in government funding for social-welfare programmes as